Big A: Maca Variant

For Five Players

A variant of the Chinese climbing game Big A (打大A), with hidden partners, bombs, and bomb-capturing 4s

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Concept

Big A: Maca Variant is a climbing game for five players with two decks of cards. Everyone tries to get rid of all their cards first.

During the draw, a player can show an Ace to become the **Declarer**. Both Aces of that suit become the **Big Aces**, the highest single cards. Whoever holds the other Big Ace is the Declarer's **Partner**, but nobody knows who that is until they show it. Declarer and Partner form the **Big A team** and play against the other three players, the **Defenders**.

The Big A team needs one of its members to go out first, and it scores more the sooner the other member follows. The Defenders try to stop them.

Setup

Players: 5.

Cards: Two standard decks of 52 cards, each with a red and a black Joker, 108 cards in all. Every card has exactly one identical **copy**.

Direction: Drawing and play go **anticlockwise**.

First drawer: Chosen at random for the first deal. In later deals, the player who went out first in the previous deal draws first.

Draw order: The first drawer, then the other players anticlockwise.

Score sheet: Pen and paper (see Keeping Score).

A Deal at a Glance

Each deal follows these steps. The sections below explain each one.

1. **Draw:** Take turns drawing one card at a time. Until your hand is full, you may show an Ace to become the Declarer.
2. **Overbid:** Until your hand is full, you may show both Aces of another suit to take over as Declarer with a public solo. Once per deal.
3. **Forced hearts:** If nobody declared during the draw, the first player in draw order with an Ace of hearts must declare.
4. **Calling:** A Declarer with both Big Aces calls a card for a Partner, plays a hidden solo, or plays a public solo.
5. **Revealing:** The Partner may reveal to raise the stakes.
6. **Tricks:** A revealed Partner leads, otherwise the Declarer. Get rid of all your cards.
7. **Scoring:** Score the places of the Big A team.

Cards

Single rank: From high to low, single cards rank Big Ace, red Joker, black Joker, 3, 2, A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4. Suits do not matter, except for deciding which Aces are Big Aces.

Big Aces: The two Aces of the Declarer's suit, the **Big A suit**. Until someone declares, every Ace is an ordinary Ace. A Big Ace is the highest single card. In every other play except the Big Ace pair bomb, it counts as an ordinary Ace.

Sequence order: In sequences, from low to high, cards run A, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, J, Q, K, A. An Ace can be low (A-2-3) or high (Q-K-A), but a sequence cannot run past it (K-A-2 is not a sequence).

The Draw

Shuffle both decks together and place them face down as the draw stack. Starting with the first drawer, players take turns drawing one card at a time until the stack is empty. The first three drawers end with 22 cards and the other two with 21. Your hand is **full** once you have drawn your last card.

Declaring

Declaring: At any time during the draw, even when it is not your turn, you may show an Ace from your hand, as long as your hand is not full. You become the **Declarer**, and the suit of that Ace becomes the Big A suit. Keep the Ace in your hand. Only the first player to show an Ace becomes the Declarer. After that, nobody else can declare, and the draw continues.

Partner: Whoever holds the other Big Ace at the end of the draw is the **Partner**. They keep this secret unless they reveal. If the Declarer holds both Big Aces, see Calling.

Overbid: Once a player has declared, any other player whose hand is not yet full may **overbid** by showing **both Aces of a different suit**. The overbidder becomes the Declarer and plays a **public solo**, with that suit as the Big A suit. The first declaration is cancelled, and its Aces become ordinary Aces. Only one overbid is allowed per deal.

Forced hearts: If nobody has declared when the draw ends, the players are asked in draw order whether they hold an Ace of hearts. The first who does must show it and becomes the Declarer, with hearts as the Big A suit. In this **forced deal**, the Declarer may not play a public solo, and the Partner may not reveal.

After the Draw

Before the first trick, follow these steps in order.

1. Calling: A Declarer who holds both Big Aces chooses one of three options.

- **Call a partner:** Name the lowest card of which you hold exactly one copy. Lowest means lowest in single rank, so 4s come first. If several cards of that rank qualify, for example the 4 of clubs and the 4 of spades, you choose. Whoever holds the other copy of the **called card** is your Partner.
- **Hidden solo:** Say nothing. You play alone against four Defenders, and the others cannot tell this apart from a

normal deal.

- **Public solo:** Show your second Big Ace. You play alone against four Defenders.

A Declarer with only one Big Ace says nothing. An overbidder already plays a public solo and skips this step.

2. Revealing: The Partner may **reveal** by showing their Big Ace, or the called card if the Declarer called one. This raises the stakes (see Scoring). There is no revealing in a forced deal.

3. First lead: A revealed Partner leads the first trick. Otherwise, the Declarer leads.

Plays

A **play** is a single card, a pair, a sequence, a double sequence, or a bomb. Table 1 lists the ordinary plays, and Table 2 lists the bombs.

Table 1: Ordinary plays

Play	Cards and comparison
Single	1 card, by single rank.
Pair	2 cards of the same rank, by single rank (33 high, 44 low). Two Jokers or two Big Aces are bombs, not pairs. A Big Ace with an ordinary Ace is a pair of Aces.
Sequence	3 or more cards in a row in sequence order, for example 5-6-7. No Jokers.
Double sequence	3 or more pairs in a row in sequence order, for example 66-77-88. No Jokers.

Beating: An ordinary play beats an ordinary play of the same type and the same number of cards if it is higher. Pairs compare by single rank. Sequences and double sequences compare by their highest card in sequence order. A play that is only equal never beats.

Bombs: A bomb beats any ordinary play, except as listed below, and any weaker bomb. Table 2 lists the bombs from weakest to strongest. Bombs of the same kind and size compare like ordinary plays. Eggs and Big Eggs compare by single rank (333 high, 444 low). Triplet sequences and Fake Eights compare by sequence order.

Table 2: Bombs, weakest to strongest

Bomb	Cards
Egg	3 of a kind.
Big Egg	4, 5, or 6 of a kind. More cards beat fewer.
2 Jokers	Any 2 Jokers. Two red beat two black.
Triplet sequence	Exactly 3 triplets in a row, for example 555-666-777.
Fake Eight	Exactly 2 four-of-a-kinds in a row, for example 5555-6666.
7 or 8 of a kind	More cards beat fewer.
3 Jokers	
4 Jokers	
Big Ace pair	Both Big Aces.

Exceptions: An Egg cannot beat a single Joker, a single Big Ace, or a double sequence. A Big Egg of 4 cannot beat a single Big Ace.

Tricks

Playing a trick: The leader makes any play. Then, anticlockwise, each player still in the deal either passes or makes a play that beats the **current play**, which is the last play in this trick. You may always pass, and passing does not stop you from playing later in the same trick.

End of a trick: The trick ends when every other player still in the deal has passed in a row since the current play. The pile is cleared, and whoever made the current play leads the next trick.

Known teams: The Declarer is known from the start. The Partner becomes known when they reveal, or when they play the Big Ace or called card that made them Partner. A solo becomes known when the Declarer shows or plays the second Big Ace. Once the Partner or the solo is known, every other player is a known Defender.

Going out: When you play your last card, you go out and take the next free place, from 1st to 5th. You are skipped for the rest of the deal. If nobody beats your last play, the next trick is led by the next player anticlockwise still in the deal who is not a known opponent of yours. For example, when the Declarer goes out, a revealed Partner leads.

End of a deal: The deal ends as soon as all players still holding cards are known to be on the same team. They take the remaining places. For example, if the Declarer and the Partner are the last two players with cards, they finish 4th and 5th.

Capturing with 4s

On your turn, if the current play is another player's Egg or Big Egg, you may **capture** it with a set of 4s that has **exactly one card fewer** (Table 3).

Table 3: Capturing with 4s

Your 4s	Capture
44	An Egg (3 of a kind)
444	A Big Egg of 4
4444	A Big Egg of 5
44444	A Big Egg of 6

The captured bomb goes into your hand. Your 4s become the current play. Two 4s count as a pair, and three or more 4s as an Egg or Big Egg. Play then continues as usual.

Only Eggs and Big Eggs can be captured. Joker bombs and 7 or 8 of a kind cannot. Sets of 4s may also be played as normal pairs, Eggs, or Big Eggs. As Eggs and Big Eggs, they can be captured in turn, for example 444 by 44.

Capturing a Big Ace or the called card never changes the teams.

Scoring

Every deal is zero-sum. First, find the Big A team's result in **units** (Table 4). Then turn the units into points for each player (Table 5). Solos are scored separately.

The places of the two team members count in either order, unless the row names the Declarer or the Partner.

Example: The Declarer finishes 1st and the revealed Partner 2nd. That is 4 units, so Declarer and Partner score +12 each, and each Defender −8.

Solos: A solo Declarer wins only by going out first (Table 6). A public solo pays more but also loses more. An overbid is scored as a public solo.

Table 4: Units for the Big A team

Places of the Big A team	Units
1st & 2nd	+4
1st & 3rd	+3
1st & 4th	+2
1st & 5th	0
2nd & 3rd	0
2nd & 4th	−1
3rd & 4th	−2
Partner 5th, Declarer 2nd or 3rd	−3
Declarer 5th, Partner 2nd–4th	−4
4th & 5th	−4

Table 5: Units to points

Partner	Declarer	Partner	Each Defender
Hidden	×2	×1	×(−1)
Revealed	×3	×3	×(−2)

Table 6: Solo scoring

Declarer's place	1st	2nd	3rd	4th	5th
Hidden solo: Declarer	+20	−8	−12	−16	−20
each Defender	−5	+2	+3	+4	+5
Public solo: Declarer	+28	−12	−16	−20	−28
each Defender	−7	+3	+4	+5	+7

Keeping Score

Write one column per player. Everyone starts at 0, and scores may go below 0. After each deal, write each player's points in one row. Every row adds up to 0, which shows a mistake at once. Keep a running total for each player.

Match End

Agree before you start how many deals to play. The player with the most points wins. If players are tied, they share the win.

Design Notes

Big A (打大A) is a Chinese climbing game for five. This variant grew over time, playing with the same group of friends, out of conversations we had about the game and a few personal quibbles.

I find the base game too forgiving to the Declarer, especially the soloist. Now the Big A team needs a 1st place, and without one it usually hurts. Playing solo is also not as lucrative or as safe as it used to be. That's fine by me, because I find defending against a soloist a bit boring, and whoever holds both Big Aces can now call a partner instead.

I didn't take the name too seriously. Maca is our cat (Serbian for "cat"), and naming the variant after her made my partner happy—the real-life one, not the one holding the other Big Ace.

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Player Reference

A Deal at a Glance

1. **Draw:** Take turns drawing one card at a time. Until your hand is full, you may show an Ace to become the Declarer.
2. **Overbid:** Until your hand is full, you may show both Aces of another suit to take over as Declarer with a public solo. Once per deal.
3. **Forced hearts:** If nobody declared during the draw, the first player in draw order with an Ace of hearts must declare.
4. **Calling:** A Declarer with both Big Aces calls a card for a Partner, plays a hidden solo, or plays a public solo.
5. **Revealing:** The Partner may reveal to raise the stakes.
6. **Tricks:** A revealed Partner leads, otherwise the Declarer. Get rid of all your cards.
7. **Scoring:** Score the places of the Big A team.

Cards

Single rank: Big Ace, red Joker, black Joker, 3, 2, A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4.
Sequence order: A, 2, 3, . . . , Q, K, A. No running past an Ace.
Big Aces: The highest singles. Ordinary Aces in every other play except the Big Ace pair.

After the Draw

Calling: With both Big Aces, call the lowest card you hold exactly one copy of, say nothing for a hidden solo, or show the second Big Ace for a public solo.
Revealing: The Partner may show their Big Ace or the called card. Not in a forced deal.
First lead: A revealed Partner, otherwise the Declarer.

Plays

Play	Cards and comparison
Single	1 card, by single rank.
Pair	2 cards of the same rank, by single rank (33 high, 44 low). Two Jokers or two Big Aces are bombs, not pairs. A Big Ace with an ordinary Ace is a pair of Aces.
Sequence	3 or more cards in a row in sequence order, for example 5-6-7. No Jokers.
Double sequence	3 or more pairs in a row in sequence order, for example 66-77-88. No Jokers.

Beat with a higher play of the same type and number of cards, or with a bomb. Equal never beats.

Bombs, Weakest to Strongest

Bomb	Cards
Egg	3 of a kind.
Big Egg	4, 5, or 6 of a kind. More cards beat fewer.
2 Jokers	Any 2 Jokers. Two red beat two black.
Triplet sequence	Exactly 3 triplets in a row, for example 555-666-777.
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7 or 8 of a kind	More cards beat fewer.
3 Jokers	
4 Jokers	
Big Ace pair	Both Big Aces.

An Egg cannot beat a single Joker, a single Big Ace, or a double sequence. A Big Egg of 4 cannot beat a single Big Ace.

Capturing with 4s

Capture another player's Egg or Big Egg with one 4 fewer. Take the bomb into your hand. Your 4s become the current play. Teams never change.

Your 4s	Capture
44	An Egg (3 of a kind)
444	A Big Egg of 4
4444	A Big Egg of 5
44444	A Big Egg of 6

Tricks

Pass or beat the current play. Passing does not stop you from playing later. When all others still in the deal have passed in a row, the current play's owner leads. After going out, the lead goes to the next player who is not a known opponent. The deal ends when everyone left is known to be on the same team.

Scoring

Places count in either order unless the row names a role.

Places of the Big A team	Units
1st & 2nd	+4
1st & 3rd	+3
1st & 4th	+2
1st & 5th	0
2nd & 3rd	0
2nd & 4th	−1
3rd & 4th	−2
Partner 5th, Declarer 2nd or 3rd	−3
Declarer 5th, Partner 2nd–4th	−4
4th & 5th	−4

Partner	Declarer	Partner	Each Defender
Hidden	×2	×1	×(−1)
Revealed	×3	×3	×(−2)

Declarer's place	1st	2nd	3rd	4th	5th
Hidden solo: Declarer	+20	−8	−12	−16	−20
each Defender	−5	+2	+3	+4	+5
Public solo: Declarer	+28	−12	−16	−20	−28
each Defender	−7	+3	+4	+5	+7

An overbid is scored as a public solo.